political experience, think it will all end, fostering the enemies of their friend? It will end in grief and regrets!"' A traveller who had just arrived from Peshawar related that:

> General Avitabile, the Sikh's governor of that city, on enquiring about the state of affairs in Kabul, and on being told that all groups, including the Barakzais, were equally favoured, turned to his entourage and sighed: 'God help that Shah Shuja and forgive him!' Those present were surprised at the expression, normally used for the dead, and asked: 'Is the King not still alive?' Avitabile answered: 'Anyone who gives room to his deadly enemies, and trustingly embraces them, will not last long. For as Firdawsi put it:
>
> > You killed a father and sowed the seeds of revenge,
> > When will he whose father was killed have peace?
> > You killed a snake and are raising its young,
> > What foolishness is this?
>
> Eventually the fruits of all the enmity will ripen. Soon you will hear that Shuja ul-Mulk has been murdered by these very same Barakzais!'[40]

There were other shadows too: one regiment returning to India had its rearguard ambushed and massacred as it descended the Khyber Pass, with the loss of 150 baggage camels; shortly afterwards the garrison of Ali Masjid had to be evacuated down to Peshawar.[41] At the same time, a senior officer, Colonel Herring, was murdered by a party of Afghans while out walking in Wardak. He had disobeyed orders and strayed from the road to chat with some Afghans on a hill. They cut him to pieces. 'It was our melancholy fate to discover his dead body,' wrote Thomas Seaton. It was 'an awful sight, hacked and mangled in the most frightful manner, with every vestige of clothing torn off, except the wristbands of his shirt. The body was nearly severed at the loins, and there was a dreadful gash across his chest and through the ribs. There were altogether sixteen or seventeen wounds, each sufficient to cause death.'[42] Yet by and large the country was at peace. Once the Ghilzai chiefs had received their subsidies from Macnaghten, they fulfilled their part of the bargain. 'The passage from Khyber to Kabul was infested with dacoits and robbers,' recounted the *Tarikh-i-Sultani*. 'They threatened all the wayfarers and travellers on that route. However, once the Ghilzai Khans took over the management of this route, these threats were removed and peace reigned for the rest of the winter.'[43]